

Chapter 69: Rebirth

Did she still want to live? She didn't know. She even pondered for a while about what "living" meant.

"If I were alive, would I not hurt like this anymore?" she asked.

That person was silent for a moment, then let out a mocking light laugh: "Not necessarily. Whether you're alive or dead has nothing to do with whether you hurt or not. When you return to the mortal world, you might suffer a hundred times more than you do now."

"It's just that if you stay here, it will be others who suffer," that person said again.

"Who?" she asked.

"The person calling you," that face flickered in and out of the flames.

Hearing this, she listened carefully again. Beyond the raging fire, it seemed quite noisy. All the sounds converged into a strange roar that made her somewhat dizzy, so she pulled her ears back and only listened to the crackling beside her.

"If I don't live, will you also be unable to live?" she asked hesitantly.

"I can live, but I don't want to anymore." That person slowed her speech, seeming to think about how to explain to a confused soul. "But if you want to live, I can consider it."

"Why don't you want to live?"

"Because the human world is full of callous people—saying one thing and doing another, breaking faith and betraying righteousness. There's nothing to live for, and nothing to mourn in death."

"Then why do you want to save me?" she asked again.

That person paused, then sighed: "Because you're not."

"Not what?" she pursued.

"A callous person." That person answered indifferently. "You saved your friend. Though your body is weak and useless, you're more righteous than those hypocritical gods."

The semi-transparent pink soul in front of her said nothing, just swaying back and forth in the raging fire, as if waiting for something. That person stared at her for a long while, finally deciding not to argue with a vengeful spirit and continued speaking.

"I once had a master. He was born of the Nine Heavens Divine Clan, destined to protect the six realms. His future was glorious, and even from a young age, he was revered by the six realms."

"And I was born a divine beast, offered to him by my clan, bound to him in contract, becoming his divine companion from then on. I cultivated together with him, grew up together, took human form together. He was diligent and studious, kind-hearted, so I revered him and willingly acknowledged him as master. Until..."

"Until what?" the vengeful spirit leaned forward.

"Until very, very long afterward, one day I accompanied him to the mortal realm for training. We encountered Jun Molan¹ of the demon clan at that time. The two fought for three days and three nights, from Zhaoyao Mountain all the way to Tongchuan. He was young and ultimately no match, and was struck down into Tongchuan's Ghost Eye² by Jun Molan. Both of us were drained of divine power by the Ghost Eye and couldn't resist the turbid energy."

When that person spoke of this, her tone was no longer casual but carried uncontrollable hatred.

"At that time, the sun was about to set. Seeing him severely injured, I gathered all my strength intending to carry him out of Tongchuan. However, just as I flew to the edge of the Ghost Eye, the sun had already set. Just as the turbid energy was about to consume our consciousness, he suddenly stood up and stepped on my body, using me as a stepping stone to leap out of the Ghost Eye at the last moment!" That person's voice grew increasingly angry, and her anger made the surrounding flames even more intense, crackling loudly.

That person was overwhelmed with emotion at this point and simply closed her mouth. Only after her rapid breathing calmed did she continue: "I never would have thought that the master I served loyally would step on my body to save his own life! His foot trampled me back to the bottom of the valley. From then on, I was consumed by turbid energy, transformed into a demon beast, and stayed muddled in that valley for who knows how many years."

The vengeful spirit listened in confusion but could feel the hatred that suddenly burst from that person, so she swayed her soul to show comfort.

"Then what?" she asked.

That person let out a laugh, her hatred dissipating considerably, and continued: "Later, you and that Divine Venerable Chu Ling happened to fall into Tongchuan and inadvertently awakened my consciousness. Only then was I able to fly out of the Ghost Eye and escape Tongchuan. But I didn't expect that tens of thousands of years had already passed—seas had become land, mountains had been worn flat, and the world I knew had long been buried in time."

"And after being eroded by turbid energy for tens of thousands of years, consuming countless living beings, I had long since become a demon beast that everyone wanted to kill. Not knowing where home was, I went to find the master who had harmed me, only to discover that all the gods had long since perished. Only a tomb remained underground, while a new nation had been built above ground."

"These tens of thousands of years were long for heaven and earth, but for me, it was as if the seas had changed to mulberry fields overnight—everything had changed beyond recognition." That person's tone fluctuated again.

"I hate the person who put me in such a situation, especially since he still wanted to be reborn, using the tomb to preserve a strand of his soul. As long as his soul doesn't perish, the contract between us continues, and even if I die, I'm still his divine beast. I refuse to accept this!"

"So I knocked out the Empress of Qi and disguised myself as her, staying in the palace, trying to enter his tomb. But divine burials can't be opened by any amount of strength, and I'm not scholarly enough to solve the mechanisms within. Just as you and Divine Venerable Chu Ling came here, I had an idea and tricked you into helping me. Only then was I able to completely destroy his body and soul, returning my innocence!"

After saying this, that person held her breath for a moment before recovering her indifference, with helplessness replacing sorrow: "I didn't want to be a demon beast, so I originally intended to die in the tomb. But you saved me from the tomb and put me in a prayer bead³, bringing me to this place."

"Though you didn't bring me down, I willingly followed you into the bronze furnace." That person shook her head, her gaze sweeping over the rolling heat waves above. "She's at the end of her strength. You must decide—return, or stay?"

"If you return, you must form a contract with me. I'll tell you in advance that my demonic energy is hard to dispel. If you form a contract with me, you'll definitely face bloody storms from the immortal sects in the future." That person's eyes were deep and profound as she spoke quietly.

The vengeful spirit also looked up, but she could only see suffocating firelight, with whispers still echoing in her ears, though those whispers were growing weaker.

She opened her mouth: "I'll return."

Clear, tinkling laughter came from the flames, followed by a strand of silver light rising from in front of her, the thread slowly extending and falling upon her soul.

Ancient, unclear scriptures rang in her mind, as if countless elders were chanting in her ears. The pain in her body intensified, and her vision suddenly turned to night. Her eyes seemed embedded in her skull, watching with her own eyes as the silver thread drew an ancient character that was finally imprinted heavily in her consciousness.

"What's your name?" she asked.

"Jiuying," that person's voice was soft and charming, "Qilin Jiuying⁴."

At the same time, above the completely collapsed tiger's den, the transparent barrier had been heated to a red glow by the raging fire. Everyone surrounded the barrier, doing their utmost to maintain its integrity and trap those vengeful spirits frantically rushing toward the human world.

Firelight from the bottom of the pit reached the sky, illuminating the dim surroundings with golden brightness.

"I can't hold on much longer!" an Eastern Courtyard disciple shouted through gritted teeth. "How long do we have to hold out!"

"Hold on a bit more! We've already sent messages to the nearest immortal sects. I'm sure someone will come to help!" Hong Ying's square face had turned red as an apple, whether from the raging fire or something else.

Rong Jin beside them looked back and suddenly shouted urgently: "Elder Pingyao, the Divine Venerable can't hold on much longer!"

Elder Pingyao, who had been controlling the barrier, quickly handed it over to Elder Jingshan upon hearing this, then retreated and freed her hands to fly to Chu Qingqiu's side. She saw that Chu Qingqiu, who had been battling the demon clan member, already had faint traces of blood at the corners of her mouth. Her face was pale as paper, her hair disheveled, and her body swaying.

"Divine Venerable!" Elder Pingyao was shocked and quickly reached out to support her, then threw her magical artifact into mid-air, casting spells to summon heavenly thunder to counter the lightning summoned by that man. For a moment, the sky was full of thunder and fire, cold-colored light repeatedly splitting the firmament, and the entire ground trembled.

However, that man's strength was truly unfathomable, and with the demonic artifact Emei thorn in hand, even their combined efforts were losing ground.

The man laughed heartily in the high sky, his eerie laughter echoing between heaven and earth. All who heard it felt both anger and chills. He waved his hand to emit waves of black smoke. Chu Qingqiu and Elder Pingyao each used immortal power to resist, both retreating repeatedly.

"Divine Venerable, what are you trying to do!" Elder Pingyao suddenly saw Chu Qingqiu disperse her immortal power and point her fingertip to her forehead, and quickly tried to dissuade her in shock. "You can't hold on anymore. The Waning Moon Formation consumes enormous energy. Using it again might..."

"The previous Waning Moon Formation only used twenty percent of its power—hardly worth mentioning. Now we're facing death anyway. Better to perish together with this demon who has repeatedly harmed people." Chu Qingqiu's clear voice sounded, carrying a desolation that didn't match her appearance. She didn't listen to Elder Pingyao's dissuasion but said, "Pingyao, help me."

Elder Pingyao couldn't stop her in time. In a blink, she had already flown into mid-air. Countless waves of black smoke surged toward her. Seeing this, Elder Pingyao had no choice but to obey, doing her utmost to help block the heavenly thunder and black smoke.

The white bones transformed into millions again, bursting with cold white light behind her. The radiance several times more brilliant than before illuminated heaven and earth. The white-clothed woman stood in the center of the radiance, her long hair rolling in the wind, her body like stars and moon.

The man in the sky changed expression upon seeing this, while Elder Pingyao suddenly called out anxiously: "Divine Venerable, wait! Divine Venerable, look back!"

The unfinished crescent in Chu Qingqiu's palm faded its radiance. Hearing this, she turned around and stood blankly in mid-air.

She saw that the previously solid barrier had been burst open with a thunderous crash, but the vengeful spirits within didn't scatter outward. Instead, they were completely consumed by raging fire that suddenly blazed into mid-air. The rootless raging fire twisted and tore in mid-air, finally reorganizing into a massive cloud-like body.

"What is that!" an Eastern Courtyard disciple who had been scattered by the airflow said in shock. "It looks like a spirit beast!"

"A spirit beast? Where is there such a large spirit beast? I've never seen one!"

"No, this isn't a spirit beast!" Hong Ying's eyes nearly popped out of their sockets. He was both shocked and delighted, shouting repeatedly, "This is a divine beast! An ancient divine beast—a qilin!"

That body suddenly roared toward the sky, the sound like crushing through the ages. Everyone's necks broke out in sweat listening to it. Accompanying the terrifying beast's roar, countless points of light suddenly rose from the originally muddy ground, like luminous dust, heading toward mid-air from all directions.

Chu Qingqiu stared blankly at the scene before her, her hands clenched until they almost lost feeling.

Countless points of light gathered before the raging fire, but their radiance wasn't suppressed by the flames. As more and more light points gathered, the rough shape of a person appeared. The light points condensed into facial features and slender limbs, finally covering them with robes.

Everyone was so shocked they couldn't speak. Liu Wenzhu stood up from the muddy ground, tears in her eyes as she covered her mouth.

"Ning Fuyi? Ning Fuyi!"

At this time, the others also recognized the woman in mid-air with her arms spread wide. She had completely grown up, no longer showing any trace of a naive young girl. Her dress fit her graceful figure, the red fabric gleaming with golden light fluttering in the wind, beautiful and passionate, stunning all those below.

While her body was being reborn, the scriptures of the contract still echoed around them.

"Ning Fuyi..." Chu Qingqiu murmured. She wanted to take a step forward, but her feet seemed rooted in place, unable to move. She could only stand in mid-air, gazing at her from afar.

A face identical to her previous life finally appeared before her unexpectedly, easily breaking through her defenses.

The man in the sky had never expected such a scene to occur. While surprised, he cursed repeatedly, hurriedly summoning heavenly thunder, combining with black smoke to form a magical array, preparing to finish off Chu Qingqiu first.

However, just as the array approached Chu Qingqiu, the sky suddenly brightened greatly. The raging fire behind Ning Fuyi finally took shape—sheep's head and wolf's hooves, mane flowing with radiance, four limbs mighty as mountains, red eyes dazzling as the sun. The angry roar belonging to an ancient divine beast resounded through heaven and earth.

The scriptures stopped abruptly. The contract was formed.

All the dark clouds disappeared in an instant. The phoenix eyes of the woman floating before the raging fire suddenly opened, her consciousness returning to its place.

A moment of confusion flashed in her eyes, then a divine sword wreathed in soaring flames and flying radiance appeared in her palm. Pink energy streams burst toward Chu Qingqiu, but when they reached Chu Qingqiu's vicinity, they dispersed and shattered the magical array that was about to strike her from behind.

Radiance consumed the black smoke, vast air currents scattered Chu Qingqiu's hair, but she didn't move at all, letting the great wind blow her robes in all directions.

The divine beast roared again, and all the dark clouds and heavenly thunder completely disappeared. The sky was clear as if washed. The man extended his Emei thorn but couldn't summon anything, momentarily so angry his eyes split with rage.

"Divine Venerable Chu Ling, today I'll spare you! We'll fight again in the future!" Seeing the vengeful spirits broken and problems arising everywhere, the man dared not continue fighting. He left these words, turned, and departed, disappearing into the horizon.

Ning Fuyi's consciousness had just returned to her body, and her head ached terribly. The reborn body wasn't yet accustomed, so her hand went soft and she dropped her divine sword, her body falling with the wind.

A figure flashed forward like a flying feather. When she opened her eyes again, she was already nestled in a woman's embrace. The woman's entire body was trembling as she held her tightly in her arms, afraid to let go as if she might lose her.

The scent of gardenias lingered at her nose. Ning Fuyi suddenly felt this scene was very familiar, so she instinctively raised her chin and skillfully nuzzled her face against the woman's shoulder, but touched wetness all over her face.

She opened her eyes wide, coming to her senses somewhat, only then discovering that the woman was actually crying.

"Divine Venerable..." She frowned and left her embrace. "What's wrong with you?"

Chu Qingqiu hung her head without speaking, her waterfall-like long hair covering her cheeks, but tears could still be seen dripping onto her clothing, as well as something she gripped tightly in her palm.

Ning Fuyi took her hand and forcibly pried open that palm, surprised to see several pieces of broken emerald jade and a bloodied palm cut by the jade.

"The bracelet..." Chu Qingqiu said quietly. "The bracelet is broken..."

Footnotes:

¹ Jun Molan (君墨阑) - A demon clan leader mentioned in the backstory

² Ghost Eye (鬼眼) - A dangerous location in Tongchuan that drains divine power

³ Prayer bead (一念珠) - A magical storage device that Ning Fuyi possesses

⁴ Qilin Jiuying (麒麟九婴) - The divine beast's full name, with "Qilin" indicating her species and "Jiuying" being her personal name